



Merit Education Group

Unit 1 Quick Reference: Expressions

Key Vocabulary, Symbols & Properties

Variable	A symbol (usually a letter) that represents an unknown quantity	x, y, n
Constant	A fixed number that does not change	$5, -3, \frac{1}{2}$
Coefficient	The number multiplied by a variable	<i>In $4x$, the coefficient is 4</i>
Expression	A combination of variables, constants, and operations	$3x + 7$
Term	A single number, variable, or product of numbers and variables	<i>In $3x + 7$, the terms are $3x$ and 7</i>
Like Terms	Terms with the same variable raised to the same power	<i>$2x$ and $5x$ are like terms; $2x$ and $2y$ are not</i>
Evaluate	To find the value of an expression by substituting numbers for variables	<i>Evaluate $3x + 2$ when $x = 4$: $3(4) + 2 = 14$</i>
Substitute	To replace a variable with a given number	<i>Substitute $x = 5$ into $2x + 1$: $2(5) + 1 = 11$</i>
Simplify	To combine like terms and perform operations to write an expression in its simplest form	<i>$3x + 2x + 5$ simplifies to $5x + 5$</i>
GEMDAS	Grouping, Exponents, Multiplication/Division, Addition/Subtraction — the order of operations	<i>$(3 + 2)^2 \times 4 = 25 \times 4 = 100$</i>

Keep this sheet handy while working through Unit 1.